VRIJE UNIVERSITEIT AMSTERDAM

Trends, hypes and accidents: Is hype a manufactured or an emergent phenomenon?

Hype Studies Hangout
27.05.2025,

Maximilian Roßmann
m.m.rossmann@vu.nl



Agenda:

1. Epistemology of hype
2. Hype Ethics
3. Counter-hype research activism
4. Final thoughts

Context

- “On occasion, I get asked “isn’t Hype Studies basically the same as Sociology of Expectations?” or “is the concept of hype the same as expectations, marketing or promises?” (Is Hype Studies just Sociology of Expectations 2.0? by Ola)
- “**Although usually regarded as a natural process, hype is never accidental: It is strategically crafted by tech and PR companies and their CEOs to over-stress the positive implications of technology while undermining the negative ones.**” (The Hype Literacy Toolkit for Journalists by Jascha, Andreu, Johannes)

Epistemology of hype

Whether **hype** is understood as an **emergent phenomenon** or **necessarily manufactured by actors** depends on the observer / theoretical assumptions.

Functionalist understanding: Hype Studies as a Sociology of Expectations 2.0?

Expectations are functional for innovation systems:

- They are performative: stabilize orientation, attract interest, provide legitimation, foster investment.
- They coordinate actors across levels and contexts by linking present decisions to imagined futures.
- They turn promises into present obligations ("promise-requirement cycle").
- They have a temporal pattern ("hype cycle").
- They relate imagination & materiality.

Functional analysis examines what "problem" a phenomenon (expectations) solves for a system – how it organizes, stabilizes, or reproduces social order in different cases.

Hype as a communication problem: inappropriate exaggeration

RQ: What defines exaggeration from communication theoretical perspectives?

Exaggeration	Communicative goals	Exaggeration mechanism
Over-generalization	Information	Underspecified or generic terms hinder accurate **information transfer**.
Over-selling	Persuasion	Malicious or bad **rhetoric** amplify benefits, urgency, or certainty.
Over-promising	Commitment	**Speech** en**acts** unreasonable promises and predictions.
Over-resonance	Social representation	Imitation and community norm alignment reinforce collective beliefs, credibility, and importance.
Over-shadowing	Attention & discourse power	**Discourse** amplifies some narratives at the expense of others.

VU

Hype Ethics

What makes exaggeration inappropriate?
How to respond to hype?

Hype Ethics: Different Systems to justify and respond to inappropriate exaggeration

- **Deontological ethics:** Hype breaches norms of honest, accurate, and context-appropriate communication.
- **Consequentialist ethics:** Hype is wrong when it foreseeably distorts trust, attention, decisions, or resource allocation.
- **Virtue ethics:** Hype reflects poor judgment, especially a lack of proportionality in allocating epistemic, communicative, and ethical attention to the issue and context.

- **Deontological response:** Clearer standards and guidelines.
- **Consequentialist response:** Better anticipation and impact assessment.
- **Virtue-ethical response:** Training and cultivation of judgment.

Counter-hype research activism:

"Hype is entering **the age of badness**"

Gemma Milne

"Hype Studies understand that ***futures can be weaponised*** as spectacle, leaving the audience in the state of capitalist realism, lingering for awe and popcorn."

Capitalist Realist sentiments by Hypestudies

Counter-hype research activism: translates critique into stories that create identity, widen audiences, and motivate action beyond academia.

Research: Gathering cases, assembling evidence, and building cumulative critical knowledge about hype.

Narrativization: casting hype producers as villains, affected publics as victims, and itself as the corrective hero that seeks to responsibilize indirect amplifiers of hype. David vs Goliath.

- **Villains:** Big tech, startups, corporate research labs, etc. ...create hype & misappropriate hype research for neo-liberal / fascist / anti-democratic intentions.
- **Indirect amplifiers:** Journalists & editors, government ministries, PR agencies & corporate comms – mostly good intentions but “naïve” or “value captured” (Nguyen).



Final thoughts: What is the difference between trend (driven by fandom? 🤳) or hype (orchestrated frenzy? 🌊)

"Although usually regarded as a natural process, **hype is never accidental**: It is strategically crafted ..." (The Hype Literacy Toolkit)

- → Whether we observe hype as emergent or as manufactured depends on our theoretical assumptions.
- → The definition is **powerful for activism**: it names responsible actors, assigns blame, and supports media literacy and counter-hype intervention.
- → **As a research definition, however, it is too restrictive because not all hype is strategically crafted.**
- → A broader approach treats hype as a family of communicative exaggerations produced with different levels of intentionality.
- → **So the issue is less whether the definition is false than whether it is sufficient for studying hype – and our aims of studying hype.**